

the sheep among the wolves with his idea that, "initial resistance aside, with further advancements, guests really won't mind as long as the drink is on time and not pricey!" Hyeon backed the thought saying that, from an operational perspective, nobody minds an automated dispense bar but, he added the caveat, in a guest-facing scenario, human interaction is non-negotiable.

Gaurav Sareen, incubation manager with Bacardi and also someone who has also been a widely recognised spirits' brand ambassador, ventured further adding: "Great cocktails aren't just about balance; a bartender adjusts a drink to a guest's preferences. A drink should feel made for you, not just made correctly, a personal touch that machines can't replace."

Perhaps, but bars that win awards aren't in the business of solely customising drinks. They have a slick menu they can replicate flawlessly and quickly at 11pm on a Saturday night, which brings in the awards...and the 'ka-ching'! Wouldn't AI do it better? Sareen would still want, "...a smile, a joke, behind the drink." Devi concurs. "Personal connection is a big part of why people go to a place." A point none of us had considered was introduced here by Angre—to the average consumer, one who isn't as blasé as a bar-veteran, the skill and showmanship will also matter, scoring yet another point for human-tenders. Wait, are we calling them that already?

But we forget one thing. A lot of AI is nothing but a slicker version of the LMGTFU—(Let Me Google That For You)—all data that AI models work with still comes from the annals of logged human interactions for their perusal. Without those, there would be no base to build from, a base that constantly needs to be added to. For Sneha Agarwal, a sommelier trained in France, and someone who feels very strongly on the subject, AI can never really know what is happening in the industry in real time so, it might always be a few steps behind. She also felt that a machine can not engage and narrate from experience like a person can.

So where does that leave us, now? Maybe I should ask Claude. People in the industry don't seem to mind AI as long as it stays in its lane. But what if it evolves to have hopes and aspirations? What if AI too comes to crave recognition and fame? Plus paid leaves, with two weekly offs? Okay, strike that last one.

To sum up, what did we all feel? "AI will take many jobs, like for my friend who always struggled with English but now has help handy," quips Devi. "How a place made you feel is what makes you come back and that part stays human," adds Sareen, quite sagely. Misra had us nodding in agreement when he signed off with: "AI doesn't threaten the sommelier, it threatens mediocrity. A guest wishes to be understood, to be made to feel special and that part cannot be programmed."

"...Yet!" I cheekily added under my breath. Let's see what changes when I revisit this story in some time.